

Directories were represented as the familiar ‘folders’, which contained files. It added support for file-names that were 255 characters long, although it still gener-



The Start menu we all know and love now

ated 8 character filenames for compatibility with DOS. Windows 95 was also when Microsoft introduced the *Registry*—a consolidated database of all software and hardware settings.

Even in Windows 95, game developers still preferred to program for graphics devices directly, and Microsoft wanted to stop them worrying about hardware so that they could focus more attention on programming game logic. They decided to provide them with an API that gave them a simpler way to talk to the hardware. This API was called DirectX, and promised the same support that DOS gave them. It took a while, but as it improved, DirectX found itself being accepted by more and more game developers.

Around the same time, Microsoft introduced its latest version of Windows NT—NT 4.0 had the strong heart of its older version and the pretty face of Windows 95. It still controlled every aspect of communication with hardware for security. It also still lacked good multimedia support, and was hence regarded as more of an enterprise OS than a home OS.



The Windows NT 4.0 Welcome screen

A Little bit More—Windows 98

Windows 98 was just a version of Windows 95 brought up to speed with the newest technologies. It now supported USB devices, and could also use the new FAT32 filesystem, which let it access drives larger than 2 GB.